

6. The Girl Who Hated Books

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Warm-up

Recite this poem in class with your teacher.
Give a suitable title to the poem. What mood does the poem convey? Discuss in class.

Say in chorus!

Books are great! Books are fun!
Books let you do what you've never done!
Read a good mystery, solve a crime!
Read about history, go back in time!
Read about a lost dog, where can it be?
Read about a giant frog under the sea!
Read a very funny book, tears go away!
Read a bright, sunny book on a rainy day!
Books are great! Books are fun!
Let's read books, everyone!

Once, there was a girl named Meena. If you looked up her name in a book, you would find that it means 'fish' in ancient Sanskrit. But Meena did not know that because she never looked up anything anywhere. She hated to read, and she hated books.

"They're always in the way," she said. And this was true because in her house, books were everywhere. Not just on bookshelves and bedside tables where books usually are, but in all sorts of places where books usually aren't.



There were books in drawers and desks, in cupboards and **chests**. There were books on the sofa and books on the stairs, books stuffed in the fireplace and **stacked** on the chairs.

Worse still, her parents were always bringing home MORE books. They kept buying books and borrowing books and ordering books from **catalogues**. They read at breakfast and lunch and dinner. But when they asked Meena if she wanted to read, she would stamp her feet and shout, "I hate books!" And when they tried to read out loud to her, she would put her hands over her ears and shout even louder, "I HATE BOOKS!"

There was probably only one person in the world who hated books more than Meena. And that was her cat, Max. A long time ago, when he was just a kitten, an atlas had fallen on his tail. It had bent the tip and from then on, he tried to stay on top of the books rather than below them.

chests
stacked
catalogues

large storage boxes usually made of wood arranged one on top of the other
books with lists of all the things that you can buy





One morning, after Meena moved all the books out of the sink to brush her teeth, she went to the kitchen to get breakfast for herself and Max. First, she climbed onto a stack of **encyclopædias** so she could reach the cereal. Then, she opened the fridge and moved a pile of magazines to get the milk. She poured some for herself and some for Max.

"Max!" she called. "Breakfast is ready!" But Max didn't come. She tried again.

"Max!" she called. "Breakfast is ready!" He **still** didn't come.

"Where could he be?" she wondered. She looked in the bathtub and behind the dryer. She looked under the stairs and on top of the clock. She found more books, but she didn't find Max.

Suddenly, she heard a loud "Meeeyooow!" She ran into the dining room and there he was, stuck on top of the tallest stack of books in the house. It was made up of all the books her parents kept buying her and she kept refusing to read. At the bottom were big, shiny picture books from when she was a baby. In the middle were alphabet books and nursery rhymes. At the top, right by the ceiling, were fairy tales and adventure stories. They were all covered in dust.

"Don't worry Max," Meena called up to him. "I'll rescue you!" She started to climb the pile of books. At first, it was easy because the picture books had hard covers, and she felt as if she were climbing stairs. But when she reached the paperbacks her foot slipped on a book of poetry.

She lost her balance and started to slide.

CRASH! The books went flying. They fell every which way, the **bindings** cracking open for the very first time, and the pages flipping apart. As they fell, strange things began to happen. People and animals started falling out of the pages and tumbling to the ground. They dropped one on top of the other, **scattering** the books and **toppling** the chairs.

encyclopædias	books which give information on many subjects
bindings	strong coverings holding the pages of books together
scattering	throwing all over
toppling	causing something to overbalance and fall



There were princes and princesses, fairies and frogs.



Then, a wolf and a purple giraffe and a troll on a log. There were elephants, emperors and a bunch of monkeys twisted up in themselves.

But most of all there were rabbits, falling this way and that. Wild rabbits, and white rabbits, and rabbits with hats.

Meena sat there in the middle of it all, too surprised to move. "I thought books were full of words, not rabbits!" she said, as six more came rolling out of a book beside her.

By now, she couldn't recognise the dining room at all.

The elephant was balancing on a coffee table juggling the good china plates. The monkeys had torn down the curtains and were using them as capes. And the rabbits were nibbling on the table legs.

troll

imaginary cave-dwelling creature, usually very ugly

juggling

throwing and catching many objects in the air one after the other

capas

cloaks

nibbling

taking small bites





"Stop!" cried Meena. "Go back!" But there was so much going on that no one heard her speak. She grabbed the nearest rabbit and tried to stuff him into a cookbook, but that scared him so much he **wriggled** out of Meena's hand and ran away. She opened another book, and four ducks flew out. She **slammed** it shut again.

"This won't work," said Meena. "I don't know who goes in which book." She thought for a minute. "I know," she said. "I'll go to everyone and ask them where they belong."

She started with one **strange** creature she didn't **recognise** at all.

"Who are you?" she asked. "A is for Aardvark!" the animal said angrily, and marched off in search of her Alphabet Book.

Then she had another idea. She picked up the nearest book and began to read aloud. "Once upon a time," Meena began. "In a land far, far away ..."

Slowly, the creatures stopped jumping and chattering. They came closer and closer to hear what happened next. Soon they were all sitting in a circle around her, listening to her read.

When Meena reached the top of the second page, the cats in the circle jumped up. "That's us!" they cried. "That's our page! That's our book!" They leapt up out of the circle, jumped into her lap, and disappeared into the book. Meena clapped it shut before they could pop out again.

She grabbed another story. One by one, she began reading all her books. And, one by one, the creatures found out where they belonged.

At last, there was just one little rabbit in a little blue coat left in the room. Meena slowly picked up a book. It was *The Tale of Peter Rabbit*.

wriggled

*twisted and turned
with quick movements*

slammed

closed with force



"Maybe I could keep this rabbit with me," she thought. She was beginning to feel lonely now that everyone else was gone.

But the little rabbit stood in front of her, shifting **nervously** from foot to foot and **twitching** his nose. He was anxious to get back home.

So, with a big sigh, Meena opened the last book. The rabbit hopped in, and with a flash of his white cotton tail, he was gone.

The house was quiet. Max sat on some books washing his face.

Meena **sighed**. "I'll never see those rabbits again!" she said.

Then she noticed that the books were **still** there, lying around her. She started to smile.

When her parents came in that afternoon they couldn't believe their eyes.

Not because the curtains were gone and the dishes were broken and the table legs were chewed up. But because there, sitting in the middle of the room, was Meena. She was reading a book.

nervously

in a worried way

twitching

moving in a sudden jerking manner

sighed

took a long deep breath





Reading

(reading for main ideas)

A. Tick (✓) the right options to complete these sentences.

- Meena did not know the meaning of her name because
 - she did not read and find out.
 - she disliked her name.
 - she forgot to find out.
 - she did not care to ask.
- When Meena's parents tried to read out to her,
 - she would listen carefully.
 - she would get lost in the stories.
 - she would cover her ears and say that she hated books.
 - she would thank them.
- Max always stayed on top of books rather than below them as
 - it was more comfortable.
 - he could see everything better.
 - he loved to climb up.
 - he was scared of books falling on him.



B. Work in pairs and answer these questions.

- Why was Meena annoyed at the sight of books?
- Where were books kept in her house?
- What did her parents keep doing?
- What did Meena do to rescue Max?
- What began to happen when the books fell down?



C. Think and answer. **(reading for inference; HOTS)**

- What made Meena read? How did that help?
- How did the animals feel when they were out of their books?

D. Discuss in class. **(value-based question)**

We enjoy reading because it helps us relate to known things and also experience things out of the ordinary. Name and describe a book that you really enjoyed. Give examples of the things that you enjoyed in the book.



Using Grammar

(the present continuous tense)



The **present continuous tense** is used to talk about actions and situations that are going on at the moment of speaking. The verb used is in the **-ing** form (playing, walking) and we usually use **is, am** or **are** before the verb.

- I am walking to school.
- They are walking with me.



A. Look at the pictures. Answer the questions using the hints. Use the present continuous tense. Discuss the correct answers with your teacher.

1. Q: What is the man doing?

A: (water, plant) *He is watering the plants.*



2. Q: What is the lion doing?

A: (chase, the hare) It is...



3. Q: What game are the children playing?

A: (play, hide-and-seek) They are...



4. Q: What is Leena doing?

A: (help, mother) She is...



(main and helping verbs)



There are both main and helping verbs in a sentence. The **main verb** shows the action. The **helping verb** comes before it. It helps the main verb. It does not show the action.

They are eating lunch.

The main verb here is **eating** but it is helped by the verb **are**.

Meena is looking for Max.

The main verb is **looking** and the helping verb here is **is**.



B. In these sentences, circle the main verbs first and then underline the helping verbs. (2T) (PS)

1. The cat is climbing on the shelf.
2. The rabbit is nibbling the legs of the table.
3. The monkeys are tearing the curtains.
4. An aardvark is marching about.
5. Meena is enjoying her book.



(the simple future tense)

We use the **simple future tense** for actions that will happen in the future.

The word **will** is used when we talk about the future (tomorrow, next week).

We will do Chapter 7 tomorrow.

You can use **I shall** (=I will) or **We shall** (=We will).

C. Fill in the blanks with shall or will. (2T) (PS)

1. My uncle _____ give me a watch next year.
2. Manju and her sister _____ wear their new clothes tomorrow.
3. I _____ get up early tomorrow.
4. We _____ have a holiday next week.



Using Words

(negative prefixes)

We can form the opposites of words by adding some letters, known as **prefixes**, at the beginning of words.

Look at these word pairs.

- kind – unkind
- pure – impure
- like – dislike
- complete – incomplete

Make the opposites of these words by adding un-, im-, dis- or in-. (2T) (CR)

- | | | | |
|-------------|---------|------------|------------|
| 1. clear | 2. tidy | 3. patient | 4. correct |
| 5. possible | 6. obey | 7. visible | 8. sure |





Assessment of Speaking and Listening



Listening

(listening to information)

Complete the sentences in your own words after listening to the passage. Then check your answers.

The children were excited about _____ because their parents had decided to take them to _____. The library had more than _____. They would be shown around by _____ who would also help them _____. The librarian knew about every _____ in the library.

Pronunciation

(consonant sounds in fan and vase)

A. Say these words aloud. Notice that the letters in bold in these words have the same sound. Your teacher will help you to pronounce the words correctly.

fan lift rough photo

B. Work in pairs and say these words aloud. Notice that the letters in bold in these words have the same sound.

vase vine drive ever love

Speaking

(expressing preferences)

A. Meena and her friend, Mohsin, are talking about books. Work in pairs. Take turns and role play their conversation.

Meena: I just finished reading *Harry Potter and the Philosopher's Stone*. Have you read it?



Mohsin: Oh yes, **that is a fantastic** book!

Meena: Isn't it? **What I enjoyed most** was its storyline.

Mohsin: **I love** storybooks. **I can't stand** comic books.

Meena: Okay, **I really like** the Fudge and Ramona books.

Mohsin: No, **I don't like** family stories much. **I prefer** adventure stories.

Meena: Oh, **those are fun**. But **I lose interest in** a book that's too long.

Mohsin: Then it **gets a bit boring**, doesn't it?

In the dialogue given above, the positive statements (what they like) are in green while the negative statements (what they don't like) are in red.

(speaking on a topic)

B. Work in pairs. Talk about books that you really like/liked and ones that you don't/didn't. Use the phrases from the dialogue.



Writing

(writing a dialogue)

Imagine you are Meena. You are talking to your friend, Mohsin, about the incident that took place in your house and how it made you take up reading. Write the dialogue.



Life Skills Activity

(critical thinking; creative thinking)

Collect interesting books from your home, neighbours and friends and set up a mini-library in your class. Choose an English period in a month and name it the **DEAR (Drop Everything And Read)** period. During this period, read a book from your library. Write a review on the book or on the chapters you have read so far. Discuss your book reviews in class.

